# 8. Beginning of Settled Life

8.1 Beginning of domestication of animals and agriculture

8.2 Special skills and various occupations

8.3 Community life based on mutual co-operation

8.4 Structure of houses

8.5 Village-settlement, kinship and family

## 8.1 Beginning of domestication of animals and agriculture

**Domestication of animals :** Domesticated animals like the dog, goat, sheep, cattle, buffalo, etc. are useful to man in many ways. There are three main steps in the domestication of a species of any animal.

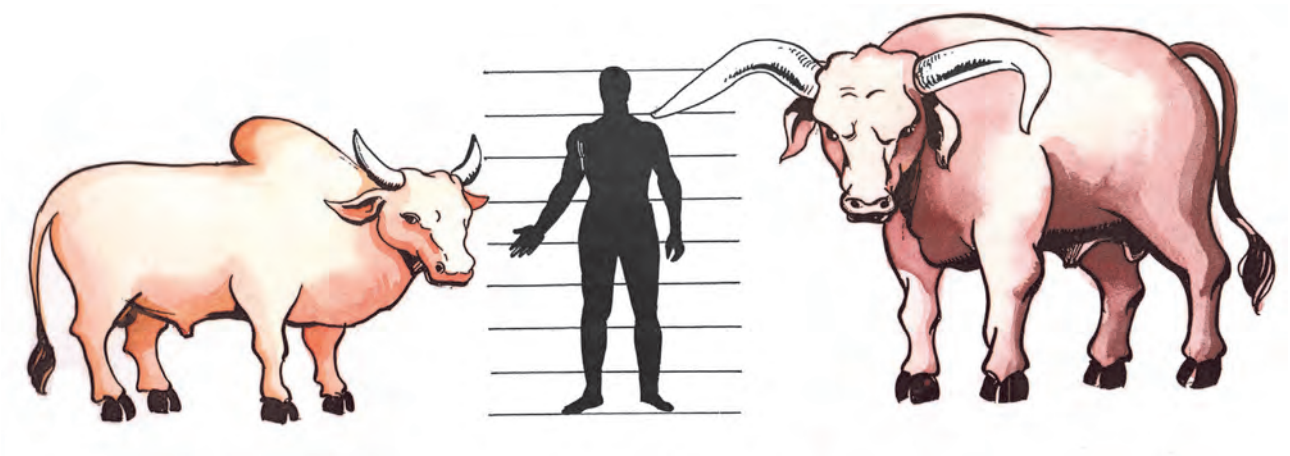
1. Capture of the wild animals.

2. Taming the captured animals; that is, training them to live with humans.

3. Obtaining useful materials like milk, etc. from them and training them to work for humans as beasts of burden.

When the third step is achieved, the animal is supposed to be completely domesticated. Domesticating animals and keeping them for our own use is called animal husbandry.

In the sixth lesson, we have seen that the dog was domesticated in the Middle Stone Age. The dog is the first animal to have been domesticated. Dogs were used to help with hunting. The goat and sheep were domesticated next.



A modern bull

A reconstruction of the ancestor of the modern bull – the wild bull

**Agriculture :** Archaeological evidence is available to show that agriculture first began about 11,000 years ago in Israel and Iraq. Women are credited to have started cultivation. They

Pointed stick and perforated stone used for sowing

Women using pointed sticks to sow seeds

might have used pointed sticks to sow seeds. Women in some tribes still sow seeds by this method. In order to help dig deeper into the soil, the stick was weighted using a perforated stone.

Plough pulled by bullocks - Egypt

In the previous lesson, we have learnt that people had to stay in one place because of the nature of agricultural work. Agricultural production increased considerably after the plough pulled by animals came into use. Agriculture became the main source of livelihood. Now people began to worship nature and various deities for good crops. Essential things like sharing of agricultural tasks and water resources and the security of the village-settlement gained importance. People in the village-settlements established some rules and customs to manage these things. Thus, a social system based on agriculture came into existence.

## 8.2 Special skills and various occupations

In the times before agriculture, people obtained food such as meat, fruits and roots by hunting and gathering, but could not store it for a long time. Therefore, all the men and women in the community were continuously engaged in getting food. In the agricultural system, it became possible to store foodgrains for long

periods. There was more food available than was needed by the community. Some women and men thus began to get spare time for experimentation and for using their natural creativity to develop special skills.

A woman potter with handmade pots

Members with such special skills were given work based on those skills. Thus arose crafts like making earthen pots, beads, etc. It is believed that in the New Stone Age women made earthen pots and other earthen objects by hand.

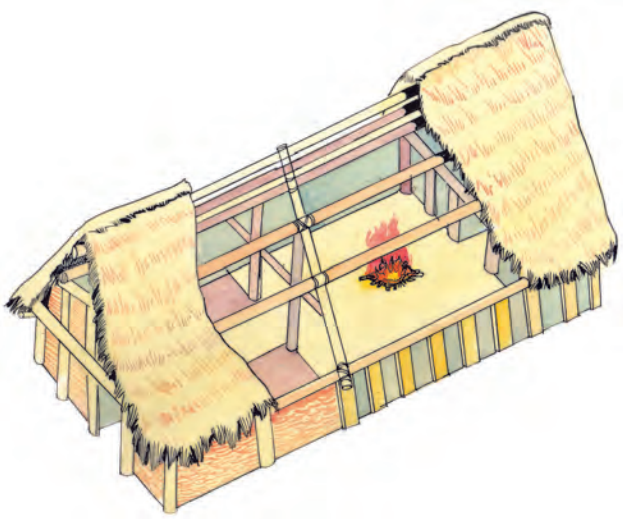
## 8.3 Community life based on mutual co-operation

The farmers in the village-settlement were now producing surplus food. They needed skilled craftsmen for tasks like making agricultural implements and repairing them. Such craftsmen were paid in the form of foodgrains or other articles. The craftsmen needed to obtain their raw material from long distances. The price of this raw material was also paid in the form of foodgrains, articles, etc. Thus the barter system of buying and selling was established. The barter system also began to be used when there was a need to obtain raw materials, finished objects, other articles of daily use, etc. from other places. Salt is an essential item. Most of the village-settlements needed to obtain it from faraway places. Salt traders also traded articles they received in exchange of salt. The salt trade helped the expansion of trade in the New Stone Age.

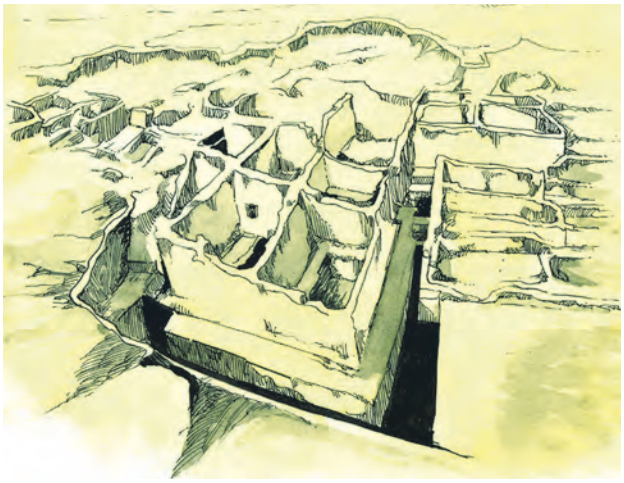
The village community made rules for mutual co-operation in order to keep this system of trade and distribution of resources running smoothly. People responsible for the implementation of these rules became the chiefs of village-settlements. The chiefs were also entrusted with the protection of the village. This is how the village administrative system came into being. Evidence of protective walls and moats around the village-settlements of the New Stone Age has been found in excavations. These walls were built to protect the village-settlements from floods, wild animals and outsiders who stole the village cattle.

## 8.4 Structure of houses

The houses at the beginning of the New Stone Age were made of wattle and daub. The walls were screens woven from sticks or bamboo, plastered with mud or cow-dung. Later, the population of the village-settlements grew because food was available in plenty. The village-settlements became permanent and expanded. Still later, people began to



A quadrangular house reconstructed from the traces of round posts and other remains in the ground.



A New Stone Age village-settlement at Mehergarh, Baluchistan

build quadrangular houses of sun-dried bricks. Some houses appear to have had more than one room. The houses were built very close to each other. Regional differences are seen in the styles of constructing houses, depending on the local climate.

## 8.5 Village-settlement, kinship and family

It appears from the plans of the houses and the village-settlements that people staying there belonged to a single clan. It means that they were all related to one another. Thus the entire village-settlement was an extended family. People living in one house were close relations but they were also members of the extended village family.

A dead person was buried either in the house or in the courtyard. Perhaps, the idea was that the person's bond with the family should not get cut off even after death. Families would also bury various articles with the dead person for them to use even after death.

## Exercises

**1. Fill in the blanks.**

(a) Archaeological evidence shows that, agriculture first began about 11,000 years ago in Israel and -------- . (Iran, Iraq, Dubai)

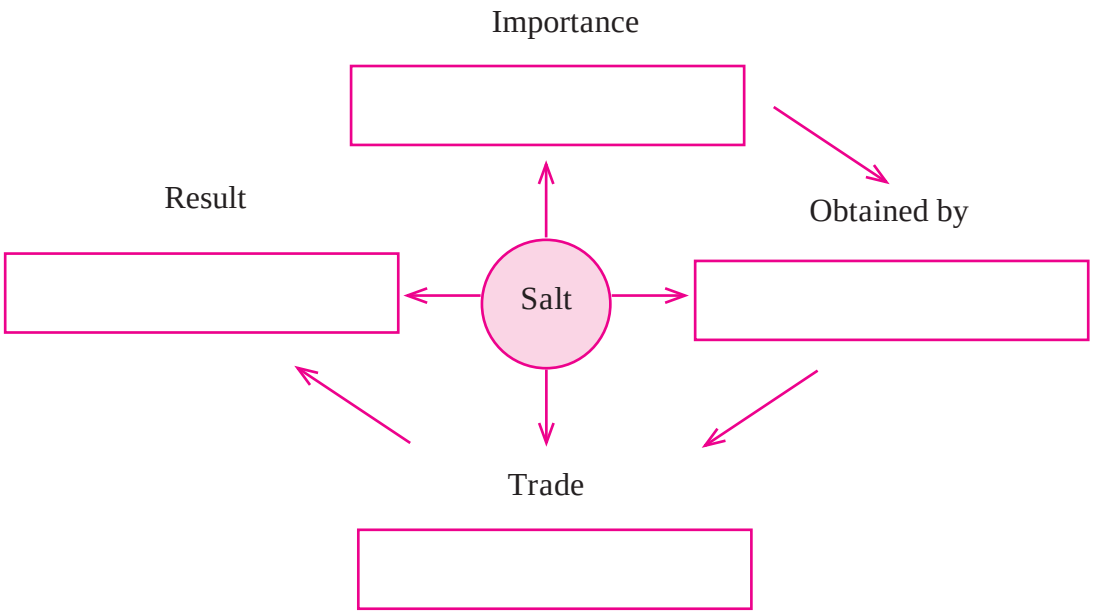
(b) The houses at the beginning of the New Stone Age were made of ---- . (earth, bricks, wattle and daub)

**2. Answer the following questions in brief.**

(a) What are the three main steps in the process of domesticating a wild animal?

(b) How did some people in the community become skilled craftsmen?

**3. Complete the following concept chart.**




**4. Write about the usefulness of any five domesticated animals.**

**5. Which animal is used by the modern police? In what way?**

**Activity**

Visit people in your locality practising five different occupations and collect information about their work.

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